

# Stale Bread

*Or The Hand That Feeds*

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Matteo Fiori wakes, sure of *only* one thing: two boys have been following him for at least three days. A white pill sits on his bedside table, beside his doctor's scribbled instructions. The young doctor had made him promise, and Matteo had promised. But what could he know? He was just a kid, barely older than those two boys.

The morning dark makes his bedroom window a mirror, but the man he sees there is old, frightened, hidden. He looks away. Another lie. The world has gone mad. He thinks: *These days, even mirrors can't be trusted.*

He reaches for the tablets and pulls his hand away. Not today. The hunted need clear eyes. I need to be able to think. He rises from his bed, pulls on yesterday's clothes, grabs his summer jacket and quietly pulls the door closed behind him.

"Matteo!" The baker picks up a loaf of yesterday's bread, stored on a shelf below the counter. He does it without looking now. He walks over to greet him. The baker stops short. "You look tired, my neighbour. Are you sleeping?"

Matteo gratefully takes the bread. "The new window looks good."

"Thanks. Those damn kids, breaking in for what, a few cannoli?"

"The world's more dangerous by the minute." Matteo pauses. "Could I borrow a knife? These old fingers aren't strong enough to tear this rock-hard bread."

"Anything for you, my neighbour."

Matteo slides the serrated blade into his jacket pocket. Its cool steel presses against his ribs.

As he opens the bakery door, he catches a reflection in the window – two slumped red hoodies sitting on the kerb. Matteo watches the hoodies from across the cobblestone pavers and waits before he continues down the street. Fear was no excuse. The pigeons will be waiting. As he walks, he forces himself not to turn back frequently; he can't afford to raise suspicion.

A red speck flashes in the side mirror of a scooter. Matteo crosses the road. They follow.

He turns the familiar corner. They turn too, closer now. The rhythm of his breath comes too quickly. He counts – the way the doctor had taught him to. In for four... hold... out for four.

He feels for the little bottle of pills in his jacket pocket. It's not there. He had left it beside his bed again. *Good*, he tells himself. *Better*. The pills make the world grow softer around the edges. Slow. A man couldn't afford to be slow whilst being hunted.

Matteo straightens his jacket. The pigeons will be waiting.

He continues on his way, glancing around. He spots the red hoodie. He flinches. He blinks. The hoodie transforms into a dress. A young woman holding her baby tight, shielding it from the dangers of the world.

Matteo lowers his eyes. *Fool, damn old fool.* He walks slower now – each step heavier. Too many windows. Too many *lying* reflections. Every sparkle catches his eye; every pane catches a red shape and throws it into his head.

He finally sees his destination. The fountain. The cobblestones. Those awnings, those kids, the pigeons.

He sits on the edge of the fountain. The pigeons recognise him and crowd around. He breaks the bread into pieces. As he crumbles it inside his palm, he spreads the crumbs, causing chaos. Wings flap, pigeons coo, begging for more. He always spares the softest crumbs for the limping grey one.

All is normal. All is better.

Out of the corner of his eye, Matteo spots the same red hoodie. His hand finds the handle of the knife. The

hoodie grows larger, closer. Matteo's grip tightens. The bread falls from his hand, scattering crumbs at his feet. The pigeons burst upward in a rushing panic of wings.

Matteo turns his head. Slowly. Carefully.

The fountain seems to fade behind him. One red sleeve moves through the corner of his vision. Behind him, something brushes his coat.

Matteo sees red.

*This is it. They're making their move.*

He stands and draws the knife. For one *foolish* second, he imagines himself steady. Brave. The kind of man who knows what to do.

Then he turns.

His arm moves before the rest of him can think. The blade flashes through the air – quick and clumsy. It finds its target – something soft behind him.

The noise of the fountain returns. The reassuring coos of pigeons surround him.

He looks down at his knife, sticky with blood. But not enough. *Not enough.*

He looks down at his feet. The limping grey one lies surrounded by her breakfast, one crooked foot

curled behind her. The softest crumbs, the ones he saved, are scattered around its trembling body.

Matteo's tears darken the feathers at its belly.

In the water of the square fountain, his reflection trembles. Not the defiant man he imagines himself to be. Only a weary old man, holding a bread knife in a trembling hand.

His neighbour, the baker, finds him there a minute later. Had he been following behind?

Matteo does not explain – only holds out the knife, handle first. “I should not have taken this.” The baker looks at the blade, then the crumbs. Without a word, he slides the knife into his apron, then places his hand on Matteo's shoulder.

Matteo flinches. Then he lets the hand stay.

They walk along the familiar street. The windows still reflect the morning light, but Matteo does not search them for hoodies now.

At his house, the baker waits for Matteo to take off his jacket and hang it back on the rack next to the door.

The pill still sits on his bedside table. The window's lies remain there in the morning light, but they are fainter now, less distinct. This time, he does not look away.

The baker stands watching, waiting. Matteo pours a glass of water. He presses the pill between his wrinkled thumb and finger and places it on his tongue.